

FREE PORT GUIDE · PORT OF CALL

Key West, Florida
Your Margaritaville at Sea day ashore

Where the Margaritaville story began: colorful Old Town, roosters in the street, key lime pie and the original Margaritaville, all a short stroll from your ship.

SHIPS THAT CALL HERE
Paradise from Palm Beach, Islander from Tampa, and Beachcomber starting in 2027

WHERE YOU DOCK
Pier B, beside Opal Key Resort at the foot of Front Street (check your daily Cruise News: piers can change)

WALK TO TOWN
Mallory Square is steps away; Duval Street is a block or two

MONEY
U.S. dollars, and cards are taken almost everywhere

TIME
Eastern time, the same as Florida, so ship time and island time match

ID
It's a U.S. port: bring your ship card and photo ID. Non-U.S. guests should carry a passport

🛳️ Stepping off the ship

At the pier

- Pier B sits right in Old Town, so you can **walk off the ship and straight into town**. No shuttle or taxi needed.
- Follow the signs through the resort grounds to Front Street. Mallory Square and Duval Street are just around the corner.
- **Booked a tour?** Check your voucher for the meeting spot. Most are a short walk away.

Getting around

- **Walk:** Old Town is small and flat, and most sights are within 20–25 minutes on foot.
- **Trolley or Conch Train:** narrated island loops, great on a hot day.
- **Bikes, electric cars, pedicabs and taxis** are all easy to find. Lock up any bike you rent.

⏰ **The golden rule:** Key West calls are often a few hours in the afternoon and evening, so plan around your exact times. Be back at the pier **at least 30–60 minutes before all-aboard**. Duval Street has a way of making time disappear!

🌴 Pick your perfect Key West day

🍹 The Margaritaville pilgrimage

5 min walk to Duval

Raise a glass at **Jimmy Buffett's Margaritaville at 500 Duval Street**, the original that started it all. Then wander over to Captain Tony's Saloon on Greene Street, where a young Buffett played to bar crowds in the 1970s. It's a must for every Parrothead.

🐓 Duval Street and Mallory Square

Steps from the pier

Stroll Duval's mile of bars, galleries and shops, and browse the waterfront at Mallory Square. If your ship is still in port at sunset, Mallory's nightly sunset celebration of street performers and food carts is pure Key West.

📸 Southernmost Point and Hemingway

15–25 min walk

Get the classic photo at the striped Southernmost Point buoy, "90 miles to Cuba." Then tour the Hemingway Home, famous for its six-toed cats, and climb the Key West Lighthouse across the street for a view of the whole island.

🏖️ Beach time at Fort Zach

About 20–30 min walk, or a quick ride

Fort Zachary Taylor State Park has Key West's best beach, with shady picnic spots, clear water and a Civil War–era fort. It's a state park with a small entry fee. The beach is rocky, so wear water shoes.

⛵ Out on the water

2–4 hours

Snorkel trips head out to the only living coral barrier reef in the continental U.S. Or kick back on a catamaran, a glass-bottom boat or a sunset sail. Book a tour that returns well before all-aboard.

🦋 Slow, shady and air-conditioned

Old Town

Step inside the Butterfly and Nature Conservatory, tour the Truman Little White House, or sip a Cuban coffee in a garden café. These are perfect picks on a scorching afternoon.

🥧 Local flavors to try

- **Key lime pie:** the real thing is pale yellow, not green. Try it frozen and dipped in chocolate on a stick!
- **Conch fritters:** crispy, peppery and the island's signature snack.
- **A fresh fish sandwich** of grouper, mahi or snapper, grilled or blackened.
- **Cuban coffee and Cuban bread** from a walk-up window.
- **Stone crab claws** in season (mid-October to early May).
- **A margarita in the town that inspired the song.** 🍹 You know you have to.

💵 Money, shopping and tipping

- It's the U.S., so dollars and cards work everywhere. Bring a little cash for tips, street performers and bike rentals.
- Tip **18–20%** at restaurants and bars, and a dollar or two per drink.
- Popular take-homes: key lime goodies, local hot sauce, rum, art from the Duval galleries, and anything with a rooster on it. 🐓
- Prices on Duval run high; side streets often have better deals.

☀️ Weather and staying safe

Key West is warm all year, with winter highs in the mid-70s and summer highs near 90°F. Summer afternoons often bring a quick thunderstorm, and hurricane season runs June through November.

👉 **Check the forecast before you go:** Key West 10-day forecast on weather.com (or scan the code).

Beat the heat

- The sun is **strong even on cloudy days**. Wear a hat and reapply sunscreen.
- Carry water and duck into shops or cafés to cool off.
- Snorkeling? Choose **reef-safe sunscreen** and never touch or stand on coral.

Smart cruiser habits

- Duval drinks are generous, so pace yourself and alternate with water.
- Watch for bikes, scooters and electric cars when you cross the street.
- The famous free-roaming chickens are protected, so admire them but don't feed them.
- Leave valuables on board, and keep your ship card handy.

🎒 Your Key West day bag

- [ ] Ship card (room key) and photo ID
- [ ] Passport, if you're not a U.S. citizen
- [ ] Sunscreen, hat and sunglasses
- [ ] Comfortable walking sandals
- [ ] Water shoes for Fort Zach's rocky beach
- [ ] Refillable water bottle
- [ ] A little cash for tips and performers
- [ ] Phone with an all-aboard alarm set
- [ ] Bike lock, if you rent a bike
- [ ] Room in your bag for key lime pie 🥧

Want the best of Key West without the guesswork?

Our travel advisors can line up snorkel trips, sunset sails, trolley tours and more that fit your ship's time in port.

📲 **Scan the code** to browse and book Key West shore excursions.

Questions? **admin@thechillcompass.com**

Information current as of October 2026, gathered from Key West port schedules, local businesses and cruise travel sources. Piers, times, prices and hours change, so please confirm with your ship's daily Cruise News before heading out. Walking times are approximate. Excursions are booked through Shore Excursions Group, and we may earn a commission at no extra cost to you. The Chill Compass is an independent blog and is not affiliated with, endorsed by or sponsored by Margaritaville at Sea or Margaritaville Enterprises. All trademarks belong to their respective owners. Presented by Cruises Tours and Travel, LLC · Florida Seller of Travel Reg. No. ST150140.